



This painting shows the destruction of the French flagship *L'Orient* during the Battle of the Nile, Egypt, where Britain's Royal Navy destroyed France's fleet.

**DESPITE THE TERMINATION OF** the War of the First Coalition in 1795, France still considered Britain an enemy. The French mooted the idea of a possible **invasion**, but it was ultimately rejected due to Britain's superior **sea power** and naval defenses. Seeking a way to get around the Royal Navy—as well as disrupt valuable trade—Napoleon proposed to attack the British on the colonial front in India, via **Egypt**, which he also hoped to conquer. Setting off from France, he took **35,000 troops**, capturing the Mediterranean island of Malta along the way. Upon reaching Alexandria in July, Napoleon quickly defeated **Mameluke** troops at the **Battle of the Pyramids**. However, on August 1,

#### Irish Revolt

Protestant prisoners, suspected of being loyal to British rule, were executed by Irish nationalists in Wexford during the revolt.



## 10–25 THOUSAND ESTIMATED NUMBER OF IRISH DEAD AFTER THE REBELLION

French forces were completely destroyed by the British navy, under the command of **Horatio Nelson** (1758–1805), at the **Battle of the Nile**. Napoleon and his troops were left stranded in Egypt, but the defeat and humiliation did little to hamper the French commander's imperial ambitions.

In 1796, the British had taken advantage of warfare in Europe to wrest the island of **Sri Lanka** from Dutch control, meeting with very little resistance. The British

named the island off India's coast **Ceylon**, and ran its administration from Madras. By 1798, the British had begun to realize the strategic importance of the island, and **Frederick North** (1766–1827) was sent there as the colony's first governor. Not all of Ceylon was under British control, however. The kingdom of **Kandy**, whose subjects occupied the interior of the island, remained independent. Their autonomy would become a cause for concern for British governors in Ceylon.

At the same time, in **Ireland**, resentment at British rule had turned to rebellion, led by nationalists called the **Society of United Irishmen**. Headed by Theobald Wolfe Tone (1763–98) and James Napier Tandy (1740–1803), the group had made numerous attempts to enlist the support of Revolutionary France, but the British, learning of these plots, had forced the rebels to change their plans. They decided to rise up, although lacking French reinforcements, and managed to seize control of **County Wexford**. A French expeditionary force sent to assist them was intercepted by British troops and the revolt soon collapsed. Tone committed suicide while awaiting his execution.

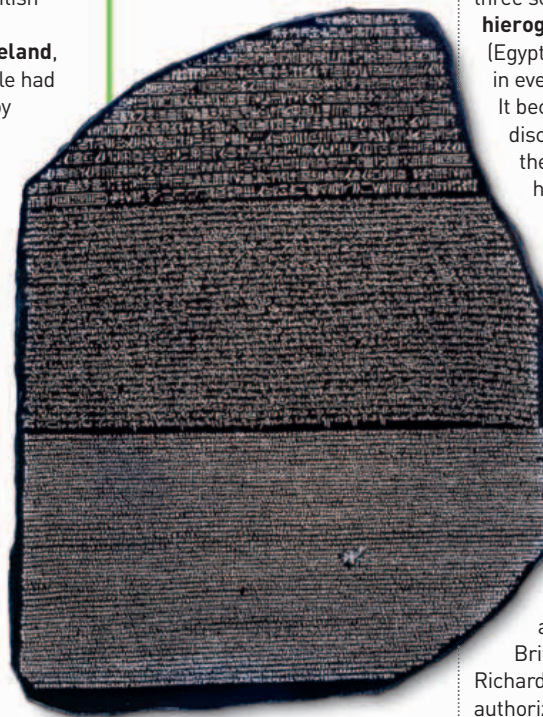
# “THE REVOLUTION IS OVER. I AM THE REVOLUTION.”

Napoleon Bonaparte, 1799

**ONCE NAPOLEON BONAPARTE** had returned to France from Egypt, he began to focus on his political future, and was soon plotting a **coup d'état** that involved dissolving the Directory, the body that had been governing the country since 1795. The outcome of the **18 Brumaire Coup** of November 9 was that the Directory was replaced with the Consulate, and Napoleon took charge of France as **First Consul**.

While in Egypt, French soldiers had unearthed an object that transformed the understanding of the ancient world. A block of black **granite** inscribed with strange writing, it was named the **Rosetta Stone** after the town where it was found. It fell into British possession by 1801, although it took years of study before anyone was able to **translate** it. Eventually scholars established a relationship between the three scripts on the stone: **hieroglyphics**, demotic script (Egyptian handwriting used in everyday life), and Greek. It became clear that this discovery would permit the transcription of

hieroglyphics, a type of communication not used since the 4th century CE. Deciphering the stone provided a window into Egyptian antiquity. In India, soldiers for the East India Company emerged victorious from a violent battle with the fearsome **Tipu Sultan** (1750–99), the ruler of **Mysore**. Tipu had made alliances with French troops in India, and on this pretext the British Governor-General Richard Wellesley (see 1797) authorized the **Fourth Mysore War**, intent on driving out the French and annexing the territory. Tipu was killed in battle, and the East India Company took half of his territory.



#### The Rosetta Stone

The translations between three different scripts on this large piece of granite unlocked the world of hieroglyphics and ancient Egypt.

Lord Mornington, later Marquis of Wellesley (1760–1842), takes up post of Governor-General of Bengal (to 1805)

May 24 First fighting of Rebellion in Ireland against British rule

July 1 Napoleon invades and occupies Egypt (to 1801)

July 21 Napoleon defeats Mameluke troops at the Battle of the Pyramids

July 14 First federal direct tax law passed in the U.S., introducing tax on property

August 1 Napoleon defeated by British at Battle of Nile

English economist Thomas Malthus (1766–1834) publishes Essay on the Principle of Population

May 4 Death of Tipu Sultan (1760–1799) in Fourth Anglo-Mysore War; British create protectorate over territory

China makes import of opium illegal

War of the Second Coalition: Russia, Britain, Austria, Naples, Portugal, and Ottoman Empire fight against France

July German naturalist Alexander von Humboldt begins his exploration of South America (to 1804)

Discovery of Rosetta Stone in Egypt

Dutch government takes control of Dutch East India Company's territories